

INSPIRATIONAL STYLES

There are many different garden styles, and whether you yearn for neat, symmetrical formality, informal cottage-garden abundance, Japanese minimalism, or contemporary urban chic, it is important to select

a look that suits both your home and lifestyle if you are to get the best from your outdoor space. Also think about how much time you have to maintain your design, as this will affect your range of choices.



Formal gardens

A successful formal garden has a balanced design, achieved through symmetry and a clear ground plan. Essential characteristics are straight lines; order and geometry; and clearly delineated garden areas. Organized around a central axis or pathway, formal gardens often focus on a key view through the garden from the house. The geometry is clear, but generous scale and balanced proportions are key considerations.

Geometric shapes feature strongly, but any regular symmetrical shape can be used as long as it sits on at least one axis. Lawns and clipped hedges are important features, the latter defining spaces or views, while dwarf box hedging can be used to edge borders, create decorative parterres, or

form knot gardens. If space allows, avenues of trees may line paths to accentuate vistas and draw the eye to a distant focal point.

Balustrades, steps, terraces, and wide gravel pathways are all key features, with the range of hard-landscaping materials, such as gravel and regular paving stones, kept to a minimum. Decorative elements, such as cobble mosaics or brick designs, are also popular in formal gardens. Other features include classical ornaments, such as Versailles cases, urns and statuary, and topiary, which is often used as a focal point. Water is an important element, and pools with reflective surfaces or jets and fountains appear in many formal designs.

Although the rules of formality are simple and clear, it is still a remarkably

ABOVE Formal by design

The use of symmetry, clear simple geometric shapes, and dwarf box edging for the borders are typical of the formal style. The central sculpture creates a focal point in the structured planting scheme.

flexible style. The overall layout can be completely symmetrical, or you can choose to adopt just a few formal elements in a more contemporary design. For example, one axis can be more dominant than another, or a series of balanced, rectangular beds can be veiled with soft, romantic planting. Another modern interpretation of the formal style is a paved courtyard garden with architectural planting, large-scale containers and a small water feature.

Many formal designs also require very little maintenance, apart from annual hedge clipping and shrub pruning.